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General Comment

See attached file(s)

Attachments

US AI Action Plan - LILT RFI Response March 2025



15 March 2025

LILT Response to AI Action Plan RFI

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Pathway to US Leadership in Foreign Language AI

Cross-border communications is a growing \$30B industry that is key to US economic competitiveness and national security.

- In the private sector, foreign language communication enables US companies to reach overseas customers and suppliers. Example use cases:
 - **Cross-border product / service distribution:** US companies spend billions of dollars per year translating their websites, user manuals, marketing materials, and software user interfaces into foreign languages.
 - **Cross-border compliance and supply chain management:** US companies spend billions managing suppliers and regulators. AI will make it easier and more cost effective for US companies to source components and sell products overseas, stimulating the national economy and reducing inflation.
- In the public sector, **foreign language AI is the answer to the persistent foreign language expertise shortage in the federal enterprise**, and to reduce billions of dollars of wasteful expenditure on contractor staffing agencies. The US Department of Defense (DOD), Intelligence Community (IC), and law enforcement agencies face “persistent challenges in developing, utilizing, and retaining sufficient language talent at the right level and expertise across the Total Force” according to a 2023 OSD report [1]. Shockingly, a 2022 GAO study cited a similar gap, meaning that in 20 years the federal enterprise has made no progress solving language skill gaps. In contrast, China has tens of millions of English speakers who can fill strategic, open-source, and offensive information warfare roles. **90% of intelligence collected by the IC is in a foreign language; Chinese and Russian are often the first level of encryption.** Foreign language AI allows the US IC to observe, monitor, and target adversaries, and communicate with US Allies who do not use English as a first language.

Specifically, foreign language AI is a critical component of the southern border mission, Operation Southern Guardian, and Operation Desert Guardian.

- Thousands of human analysts and linguists conduct these missions working with minimal AI technology assistance.
- **This human-intensive approach results in hundreds of millions of dollars of unnecessary spending on contract staffing agencies each year.**
- It also creates a backlog of intelligence that never gets processed and prevents critical intelligence from reaching US military leaders in time to be used.
- Despite the critical importance of foreign language skills to the Department of Defense's missions, the U.S. Army, U.S. Air Force, and U.S. Navy all face an acute foreign language personnel shortage stemming from three primary factors:
 - The training pipeline for DoD linguists costs the government more than \$350,000 per trainee.
 - More than half of language training recruits fail to pass the academically difficult curriculum.
 - Those that do pass require a minimum of 18 months to achieve basic language proficiency.
 - Many linguists leave the services following their minimum service time.
- Further, across civilian federal agencies, many agencies utilize bilingual employees to translate foreign language content. Examples include:
 - FBI, DEA, and law enforcement agencies routinely translate foreign material in support of their investigations.
 - U.S. Citizenship and Immigration Services utilizes bilingual employees for translations, rather than professionally trained translators.
 - Transportation Security Administration signage and materials are translated, yet the agency does not employ linguists.

Foreign language AI is being transformed due to advancements in AI, but foreign-owned companies including DeepL (Germany) and iFLYTEK (China) are rapidly securing global market share and making moves to dominate this space. **In 2019, iFLYTEK, whose foreign language AI is used by the Chinese military and intelligence apparatus, was added to the Commerce department Entity List.** [3]

The United States can harness the power of U.S. business and innovation, counter foreign advances in foreign language AI, and accelerate DoD/IC missions by taking concrete steps to build the next generation of foreign language AI companies.

The United States should accordingly:

1. Allocate additional directed funding to the DoD for investment in American companies building foreign language AI.
2. Establish a DoD task force focused on emerging foreign language AI technologies.
3. Develop a strategy for accelerating the growth of American foreign language AI companies with a focus on non-traditional vendors.
4. Direct additional funding to agile acquisition organizations within DOD such as DoD that can provide foreign language AI tools to service components with foreign language investigation missions.
5. Set up a liaison office within DoD DIU to advise allies/partners on successful American AI innovations that have been adopted/fielded by the US DoD.

6. Direct DoD to conduct a review of foreign language AI processes that are ripe for automation.
7. Recognize ATOs between services, mission centers, and agencies, so that the government can procure and deploy these tools efficiently and rapidly.

REFERENCES

- [1] US DOD. 3 Aug 2023. [Roadmap for Cultivating and Managing Skilled Language, Regional Expertise, and Cultural Talent](#).
- [2] GAO. January 2002. [Human Capital Approach Needed to Correct Staffing and Proficiency Shortfalls](#).
- [3] Commerce Department. March 2025. [Entity List](#).